Lesson 43: The Essay Introduction

English Stage 2 (B2) · Unit 4: Words, Word Order and the Essay

Adapted from Building Academic Writing Skills by Lin Cui, Harper College (CC BY-NC-SA 4.0): Unit 6 Essay Introduction.

In this lesson

You move from writing paragraphs to writing essays. You compare a paragraph and an essay by the same student writer, learn the parts of a five-paragraph essay (hook, thesis statement, supporting paragraphs, concluding paragraph), and practise writing thesis statements, introductory paragraphs and an outline. Essays are the most common writing assignment in college courses, so this is a key step in your academic writing.

Learning goals

After this lesson you should be able to:

- Explain the similarities and differences between a paragraph and an essay.
- Find the hook, the thesis statement, the topic sentences, the transitions and the conclusion in an essay.
- Write a thesis statement and an introductory paragraph.
- Make an essay outline and write a five-paragraph essay from it.

Key language

Word or phrase	Meaning	Example
essay	a group of paragraphs about one main idea	"My Joy in Baking" (five paragraphs)
introductory paragraph	the first paragraph of an essay: a hook and a thesis statement	hook + thesis statement
hook	the first sentences of an essay; they introduce the topic and get readers interested	"A hobby is a regular activity performed for enjoyment during spare time."
thesis statement	the sentence with the main idea of the whole essay, usually at the end of the introductory paragraph	"This is why baking became and has always been my favorite hobby."
topic sentence	the sentence with the main idea of one paragraph, usually at its beginning	"The first place is in the neighborhood."
controlling idea	the writer's opinion or feeling about the topic	baking is my **favorite** hobby
supporting paragraph	a body paragraph: a topic sentence with one supporting idea, and many details	paragraphs 2, 3 and 4

Word or phrase	Meaning	Example
concluding paragraph	the last paragraph: it restates the main idea or summarizes the main points	paragraph 5
outline	a plan that shows the ideas of an essay in order	Hook, Thesis statement, Topic sentence 1 ...
transition	a word or phrase that connects ideas and guides readers	Secondly, Most importantly
expertise	expert knowledge and skills	expand your writing expertise to essays
expand	make bigger or longer	expand an existing paragraph into an essay
endeavor	many efforts, hard work	Helping others does not have to be a huge endeavor.

Rules and explanations

Paragraph and essay

A **paragraph** is a group of sentences about one main idea. An **essay** is a group of paragraphs about one main idea. An essay can be three paragraphs or many pages long; in this course you write five-paragraph essays.

The same in both: one topic and one main idea; academic style (logical, direct, formal, clear, concise); a title, a beginning, a body and a conclusion; interesting, detailed support for the main idea; transitions; good sentence structure, grammar, spelling, punctuation, capitalization and format.

Differences	Paragraph	Essay
Name and position of the main idea	topic sentence, usually at the beginning	thesis statement, usually at the end of the introduction
Supporting details	some details	more details
Length	one paragraph	three or more paragraphs (here: five)
Planning and writing time	shorter	longer

The five-paragraph essay

- Paragraph 1, the **introductory paragraph**: a hook, then the thesis statement as the last sentence.
- Paragraphs 2 to 4, three **supporting paragraphs**: each begins with a topic sentence (one supporting idea of the thesis) and has many details: facts, explanations, examples.
- Paragraph 5, the **concluding paragraph**.

A good way to start is to expand a paragraph you have written. In the book's examples, the paragraph's main idea becomes the thesis statement, each supporting idea becomes a supporting paragraph with

more details, and the essay adds an introductory paragraph and a concluding paragraph.

The hook

A coat hook on the wall holds your coat; a hook at the beginning of an essay holds the readers' attention so that they keep reading. It introduces the topic and gets readers interested. The most common hooks give **background** ("When I was a child, I had an opportunity to come to the United States a few times ...") or **general information** about the topic ("A hobby is a regular activity performed for enjoyment during spare time.").

The thesis statement

The rules for topic sentences also apply to the thesis statement:

- It has a topic and a controlling idea, and it may have predictors (words that name the supporting points): "The three places to make friends in the U.S. for me are my neighborhood, school, and church."
- It is a complete sentence (subject + verb).
- It cannot be a question, an announcement or a fact.

Supporting paragraphs, transitions and conclusion

- The rules for a paragraph also apply to an essay, but an essay has more supporting details.
- Use transitions to connect the supporting paragraphs. The transition before the first supporting idea and the one before the conclusion are often optional. "Finally" is for the last supporting idea, not for the conclusion.
- Make an outline first. Delete information that does not support the main idea.
- The conclusion usually restates the main idea or summarizes the main points. It can also give an opinion, a prediction or a recommendation, or ask a question. It must not bring up a new topic.

Outline template

Parts of an essay	Outline ideas
Introductory paragraph: hook	
Introductory paragraph: thesis statement	
Topic sentence 1 / Details 1	
Topic sentence 2 / Details 2	
Topic sentence 3 / Details 3	
Concluding paragraph	

Your lesson material has a completed example for the thesis "I encountered some surprises in my first few weeks of living in the U.S." (Section V).

Practice

Warm-up. Paragraph or essay? Read the paragraph and the essay "Places in Making American Friends" in your lesson material.

1. What is the main idea in the paragraph? What is the main idea in the essay?
2. How many paragraphs does the essay have?
3. What are the three places of making American friends in the paragraph? Are the same three places explained in the essay?
4. What does the essay have that the paragraph does not?

Paragraph and essay: "My Joy in Baking". Read the paragraph and the essay in your lesson material. Answer each question for both.

1. What is the sentence that contains the main idea?
2. Where is the main idea located?
3. How many paragraphs are there?
4. What are the three supporting ideas?
5. What are the transitions connecting the supporting ideas?
6. What does the conclusion include?

Exercise 1. Thesis statements. Use the expressions below to write thesis statements.

Example: surprises / U.S. → I encountered some surprises in my first few weeks of living in the U.S.

1. children / parents' influence
2. marriage / fights
3. dream job / hard work
4. self-discipline / success
5. bilingual / benefits
6. money / problems
7. government / assisting college students
8. personality / happiness

Exercise 2. Introductory paragraphs. Study the introductory paragraphs of "Places in Making American Friends" and "My Joy in Baking". Then choose two of your thesis statements from Exercise 1 and write an introductory paragraph for each: a hook first, then the thesis statement as the last sentence.

Exercise 3. Outlines. Use the example outline in your lesson material. Write an outline (template above) for each of your two topics from Exercise 2.

Essay analysis. Read essay #1, "My First Surprises in the United States", in your lesson material.

1. What is the hook?
2. What is the thesis statement? Where is it located?

3. What is the topic sentence of each body paragraph?
4. What transition does the writer use at the beginning of each body paragraph?
5. Is the essay mainly enumerative or narrative? In what order are the supporting paragraphs organized (order of importance or chronological order)?
6. What types of information does the writer use in the conclusion?

Speak with your tutor

- "Ask me how I make friends in a new place, like the warm-up discussion. Ask two follow-up questions and correct my grammar."
- "Ask me the discussion questions about essays #2 and #3 in the lesson material ('The City Where I Grew Up' and 'A Terrifying Earthquake'). Tell me if my answers are right."
- "Here are my thesis statements from Exercise 1: [paste]. Does each one have a topic and a controlling idea? Is any of them a question, an announcement or a fact?"
- "Here is my outline: [paste]. Do all my details support the thesis? Is anything off topic?"

Writing task

Write a five-paragraph essay of about 400 to 600 words (the book's essay writing assignment). Choose one topic:

1. Expand one of the paragraphs you have written in this course into an essay.
2. Use one of your thesis statements, introductory paragraphs and outlines from Exercises 1 to 3.
3. A new topic: three things you want to change about your college or university; three things (or events, or people) you wish to forget; the three most important ways people in your country express love; the most memorable day in your life; how you overcame a challenge in your life.

Brainstorm, make an outline with the template, then write. Your essay needs a title, an introductory paragraph with a hook and a thesis statement, three supporting paragraphs (each starting with a topic sentence followed by lots of details), and a concluding paragraph, with transitions between the supporting paragraphs. Type it double spaced and indent the first line of each paragraph.

Self-editing checklist:

- Is my essay clear and easy to understand?
- Do I have an interesting hook, and a clear thesis statement at the end of the introductory paragraph?
- Does each supporting paragraph begin with a topic sentence and include lots of details?
- Did I connect the supporting paragraphs with appropriate transitions?
- Does my concluding paragraph restate the main idea or summarize the main points, without a new topic?
- Did I use correct sentence structure (simple, compound, complex)?
- Did I check nouns, pronouns, word forms, word order, spelling, punctuation and capitalization?

- Did I follow the format (title, indented paragraphs)?

Paste your draft into the chat and ask your tutor for feedback. Then rewrite it.

Answer key

Warm-up

1. Paragraph: "There are three places to make friends in the United States." Essay: "The three places to make friends in the U.S. for me are my neighborhood, school, and church." (the last sentence of the first paragraph)
2. Five.
3. The neighborhood, an American school and a church. Yes, the essay explains the same three places.
4. An introductory paragraph with a hook (the writer's background) and a thesis statement; more details in the supporting paragraphs (for example, swimming and playing with dogs, classmates and teachers who spoke slowly and patiently); and a separate concluding paragraph.

Paragraph and essay: "My Joy in Baking"

1. Paragraph: "Baking is my favorite hobby." Essay: "This is why baking became and has always been my favorite hobby."
2. Paragraph: the first sentence (the topic sentence). Essay: the last sentence of the introductory paragraph (the thesis statement).
3. Paragraph: one. Essay: five.
4. The same in both: (1) learning to bake as a child was not easy, but she enjoyed it and it gave her confidence; (2) as an adult, baking relaxes her and relieves her stress; (3) sharing her baking with family and friends gives her joy and makes the relationships stronger.
5. Paragraph: "When I was a child", "Now", "also" ("I also like to share ..."). Essay: no transition before the first supporting paragraph (it is optional), then "Now" and "Most importantly".
6. Paragraph: the main idea again ("These are all the reasons why baking is my favorite hobby.") and a recommendation ("I would recommend it to anyone who loves sweets ..."). Essay: a general statement about hobbies, the main idea with a plan for the future ("I intend to enjoy it for many more years to come."), and the same recommendation.

Exercise 1 (example answers)

1. Parents have a strong influence on their children's habits, values and goals.
2. Even happily married couples have fights, but they solve them in healthy ways.
3. Getting my dream job as a psychologist will take years of hard work.
4. Self-discipline is the most important key to success in college.
5. Being bilingual brings benefits at work, in travel and in family life.
6. Having too much money can cause as many problems as having too little.
7. The government should assist college students by offering more scholarships and cheaper housing.
8. A positive personality is one of the keys to happiness.

Exercise 2 (example answer, for thesis 4) Many students start college with big dreams. They want good grades, a degree and an interesting job. However, college life is full of distractions, such as social

media, part-time jobs and friends who want to go out. The students who reach their goals are not always the most talented ones. Self-discipline is the most important key to success in college.

Exercise 3 (example answer, for thesis 4)

- Hook: big dreams; many distractions in college life.
- Thesis statement: Self-discipline is the most important key to success in college.
- Topic sentence 1: managing time. Details: weekly schedule, study before social media.
- Topic sentence 2: going to every class prepared. Details: reading, notes, questions.
- Topic sentence 3: taking care of health. Details: sleep, exercise, healthy meals.
- Concluding paragraph: the three habits again; self-discipline is hard but brings success.

Essay analysis

1. Background: she came to the U.S. from Tokyo with her son in 2017, and living in a foreign country was a totally new experience for her.
2. "I encountered some surprises in my first few weeks of living here." It is the last sentence of the introductory paragraph.
3. "The first surprise was about the nature." / "Second, I was not prepared for some customs here." / "What shocked me the most was that people were very friendly toward strangers."
4. "The first surprise", "Second", "What shocked me the most".
5. Enumerative: it lists three surprises (nature, customs, people). Order of importance: it ends with what "shocked me the most".
6. A summary of the three surprises (nature, customs, people), the writer's opinion ("This is a wonderful country.") and her feelings now ("I'm enjoying my life here now and feel that this is my second hometown.").

My notes